MODULE 2 · STAY SAFE

Digital Safety

StreetSmarter : Because no one taught us this stuff www.streetsmarter.in

A huge chunk of your life happens on a screen, your friendships, your reputation, your money eventually. Digital safety isn't about being scared of the internet. It's the same idea as wearing a helmet, a few habits that cost you nothing and protect you from the stuff that actually goes wrong.

1. Lock Down the Basics

- Use a different password for every important account, and turn on two-factor authentication (2FA) wherever it's offered, especially email and banking apps.
- Never share an OTP with anyone, ever, even if they claim to be your bank, a delivery agent, or a prize official. No legitimate organisation ever needs your OTP over a call or message.
- Check your privacy settings on every app. "Public" and "Friends only" are very different things, know which one you're actually on.
- Think before you post. Screenshots outlive deleted posts, and colleges and employers do look people up.

2. Spotting Scams and Phishing

Most online scams follow the same basic shape, once you see the pattern once, you'll spot it every time after.

- Urgency is a red flag. "Act now or lose your account/prize/order" is designed to stop you from thinking.
- If it's too good to be true, a free iPhone, a guaranteed investment return, a part-time job paying way above market rate, it's not true.
- Never click links in messages from unknown numbers or accounts, even if they look like they're from a bank, courier, or exam board. Go to the official website or app directly instead.
- Fake customer care numbers circulate widely online. Always get support numbers from the company's official website or app, never from a random search result or comment.

3. Cyberbullying and Online Harassment

Repeated mean messages, being excluded from group chats on purpose, someone impersonating you, or rumours spreading through screenshots, all of this counts as cyberbullying, and none of it is something you have to just handle alone.

- Don't respond or engage. Reacting is often exactly what's wanted, and it rarely helps.
- Save evidence. Screenshot the messages, note the date and account name, before you block anything.
- Block and report the account on the platform itself, most apps have a direct report option for harassment.
- Tell a parent, teacher, or another adult you trust. This isn't tattling, it's exactly what that support is there for.

4. A Few Red Flags Worth Knowing

Most online risk to teens doesn't look dramatic at first. It usually looks like a new online friend being unusually nice, fast.

- Anyone who asks you to keep the conversation secret from your parents or friends is showing a red flag, regardless of who they claim to be or how old they say they are.
- Pressure to move a conversation to a different, more private app quickly, or to share personal photos or video calls, is a red flag too.
- No photo or video is ever "worth it" to send under pressure, even to someone you know and trust. Once it's sent, you no longer control where it goes.
- If something has already happened, it is not your fault, and telling a trusted adult or reporting it is the way out, not something to be ashamed of.

Tool Spotlight: Where to Report

India has dedicated, free helplines and portals for exactly these situations. Save these somewhere you can find them fast.

- National Cyber Crime Helpline: call 1930, or file a complaint at cybercrime.gov.in, for hacking, financial fraud, cyberbullying, or online harassment. It runs 24x7.
- POCSO e-Box (ncpcr.gov.in): a confidential online complaint system for reporting child sexual abuse or exploitation. A child can file it directly, without needing an adult to do it for them.
- Childline: call 1098, a free 24-hour helpline for any child or teen in distress, for any reason, not just online issues.

Cybercrime Reporting Portal · *report online harassment, fraud, or exploitation, or call 1930*

NCPCR / POCSO e-Box · *confidential reporting for child sexual abuse or exploitation*

5. The Quick Dos and Don'ts

- Do use 2FA and unique passwords. Don't reuse the same password everywhere.
- Do think twice before posting your location in real time. Don't broadcast that you're home alone or away on holiday.
- Do verify unknown links and numbers independently. Don't click first and check later.
- Do save evidence of harassment before blocking. Don't just delete and move on, in case you need it later.
- Do tell a trusted adult if something feels wrong. Don't assume you have to sort it out alone.

A Few Myths, Busted

Myth	Fact
Reporting cybercrime takes forever and probably won't help.	The National Cyber Crime Portal and 1930 helpline exist specifically to act fast, especially for financial fraud, where speed matters most.
If I share something and regret it, there's nothing I can do.	You can report it, request takedown through the platform, and get help through official channels. Acting quickly genuinely helps.
Cyberbullying isn't a "real" problem, it's just online.	Online harassment is a real, reportable issue, and platforms and Indian law both treat it seriously.

Useful Links

Cybercrime Reporting Portal · *report fraud, hacking, or harassment, or call 1930*

NCPCR / POCSO e-Box · *confidential reporting for child sexual abuse or exploitation*

Childline India · *call 1098, free 24-hour helpline for children and teens in distress*

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